

PREMISE DELTA v0.8 · THE TRUSTING FORGERY, SIXTH CUT · 2026-09-11 (released by Stephen 2026-09-11: "accept all and try again")

Eighth delta against premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 with amendments v1.5 to v1.8. History: v0.1 and v0.2 rejected; v0.3 REWORK / REJECT; v0.4 to v0.7 REWORK / REWORK, with Fable declining four times to attack the device and its confidence in the fifth round "high on the driver and moderate on the rest". Every finding of every round has been walked with Stephen and answered from the world (...-v0.7-disposition-2026-09-11.md and its predecessors). This document is v0.7 with the fifth round's ten answers built in. Two are structural and flagged. Premise v8.1 remains in force until this survives and Stephen rules.

A note to the reviewer: sections 8 to 12 record the five previous rounds' findings and the answers now built in. Attack the answers. A finding re-raised without engaging its answer does not count.

1. The device

Before (v8.1, ruled). A dead woman's accusation tears four friends apart. Her key letter: I think one of you is planning to kill me. The locker letter, forged: I know. Chapter 7: dead women don't get surer.

After (v0.8). A woman who trusted four people completely asked them, from behind a padlocked door, to find out who had been getting into her house. She said it was none of them. She had changed her lock and told only the four where the new spare lived, and it had happened again after, so she knew what the arithmetic said, and she wrote down that she would rather be imagining it. Within a month the four were sure it was one of them. Violet never accuses anyone. The accusation is built at Ruby's kitchen table by the four themselves, out of true things, and the true things were chosen by the one of them who killed her, who also wrote one kind line about himself that only one person alive can know is false.

Everything downstream holds as ruled: the room lands on Liam, Margo keeps her silence, Brad vanishes off Kestrel Head on Day 60, Margo dies there on Day 214, the survivors accuse each other to the police, the police look properly and find nothing, Ruby talks to the Gazette, Ally begins.

2. Violet

Forty-four, the best judge of a hand on the coast, and she writes everything down, dated and timed. No will, so her sister, as next of kin, will administer everything, which is the irony of the fight over their mother's house. She has money her friends know about and do not ask about, and she has been open-handed with it: eight years ago she set Brad up, the van and his first stock, in cash, on no paper, against Margo's advice. All four know that. What none of them but Brad and Margo know is that this autumn she started calling it in, for the lawyer in the fight with her sister: the solicitor's account for the hearing falls due at the month's end, she told Brad on Day -110 she wanted the van money by then, and she told him what she would do on the first of the month if it had not come: have Margo write it up properly and start asking where the van money had gone. She said at the café once, in passing and without a name, that she was calling in what she was owed.

This autumn, inside her own house. Her tobacco, two a day rolled from the tin under the stairs among the paints and the garden concentrates, comes up stained through the paper; the lid is loose; the capped bottle on the shelf above has moved six inches or has not. She bins the tobacco that day. **Day –37, the day after, she changes the front door lock (structural change this round)**, has one new spare cut, puts it in the second pot by the yard door, and tells the four on the slip, in one sentence, because the spare is for them: Liam has let himself in to check on her for twenty years. She does not say why. Then, in the weeks after the change, her mother, on the shelf in the back bedroom, is facing the door one morning when she leaves her facing the window. That is the trap she writes from. After the lock, five people knew the pot, and one is her. So either it is one of the four, which she cannot believe, or she is imagining it, which she would rather. To tell them is to accuse them. So she writes it down, for after. And a gilded alphabet panel comes down out of her workshop roof with a ceiling board: her own alphabet, better than she has ever done it, signed with a mark that is not a name.

She carries the panel round the trade asking whose hand it is: the café, the cinema, two other signwriters. Two say yours, in a very good year, and one asks the obvious question: have you shown your lad? She shows him last, on the morning of Day –19, at the sheds, with the panel under her arm on its way into her store. He looks at it a long time and says yours, and names the R. Three yours. What she tells herself is that it cannot be his because she never taught him leaf and he never asked; what she writes is that everyone says it is hers and she did not make it. The other three never see it. Nobody in town knows Brad can gild; his boat names are painted, the leaf work at the yard was always hers, and his leaf and size come by post to his box.

Her store at the slip boatsheds is one of the old brick boat stores: a bay, a steel door on a shrouded hasp, nothing visible from outside, where she kept her hull kit. Paid a year ahead in cash to the market manager, who lets forty bays for cash to people who do not want questions asked and asks none; no receipt; in no ledger Margo ever saw. She moves the kit to the van. **The morning of Day –19, in her book with times:** four keys cut on Lantern Street at nine, the packet's two dropped off the end of the slip; the panel, the letter and her mother into the store and the closed-shackle marine padlock on at ten, with Brad watching; the four keys into four envelopes at Civic Row before noon, addressed as she addresses them, Brad's to the box that is on his van, to be posted after her funeral. He asks; she makes a joke about her sister. The keys are never in her house. Then she gets on, calmer, because it is out of her head. She does not expect it to be needed.

3. The three letters, sketched (Fable writes prose, blind)

The key letter (genuine; four identical copies; posted Saturday Day 12; three by home delivery, one to a post office box; the solicitor's slip in each lists the four addressees as instructed). If you've got this, I'm dead, and I'm sorry about the timing. Go to my store at the boatsheds by the slip. The padlock's new and these four keys are the only ones. Go together, all four of you, and read what's there together. Violet. Nothing else.

The locker letter (genuine; dated Day –19; Brad reads it at 07:20 on Day 14; burned in his own grate that evening with his drafts and her book). It isn't any of you four, and I'd know. Someone with my key has been in my house, or I have started imagining things, and I cannot tell which, and both frighten me. I changed the lock in October and told only you four where the new spare lives, and it happened again after, so I know what that says, and I would rather be losing my mind. The tin: the two a day she lies about, the stain through the paper, the loose lid, the bottle on the shelf above; I don't know whether I did that; I've thrown the tobacco out. The panel: the leak, the board, her own alphabet done better than she can do it, a mark for a name; Brad says it's mine, everyone says it's mine, I didn't make it; and if I didn't, somebody has

been in my roof. Mum, facing the door; I've put her in here. Then her instruction, with her reason in it: somebody got the place of my spare from one of you without your knowing, or watched one of you use it; so write down everything odd this year, about me, and about who has been near each of you, asking, or hanging about, or in your houses; and read the four lists together at one table. Then the police, with something in your hands. Write legibly. Nothing about money: the calling-in is a lawyer's bill, not an oddity. Brad reads it and knows what the room never will: pooled, the odd things about him name a man preparing to leave, and the panel names a gilder.

The locker letter (forged; dated Day –19 as she dated everything; what the four read at nine that night). Her paper and her pen, taken from the workshop on Day –9 with nothing else; drafted from Day –9 at his own bench from what her book said she had noticed, and conformed to her true letter on the morning of Day 14, at his bench, in two hours. Her frame, kept: it isn't any of you four, and I'd know; someone with my key has been in my house, or I'm imagining it, which frightens me more; I changed the lock in October and told only you four where the new spare lives, and it happened again after. Her reason for the scale, in her voice: I don't think I'm going to die. I think I'm going to be sixty and embarrassed. But I'm putting this where it can't be got at, because if I'm wrong nobody needs to know, and if I'm right you'll want to know what I noticed. If I'd told you now you'd have sat in my kitchen with a torch and I'd never have heard the end of it. The object: I have put Mum in here with this. One morning last month she was facing the door, and I leave her facing the window. Somebody has been in the back bedroom, or I have started moving things and forgetting. Either way she is not staying on a shelf for whoever it is to stand and look at. Keep her where all four of you can see her until this is sorted. Her instruction, kept with its reason: somebody got the place of my spare from one of you without your knowing; write down everything odd this year, about me, and about who has been near each of you, and read it together at one table. Then, "since I'm asking you to, here's mine", bare fact only, nothing she was not present for: Liam has owned a third of the yard for eight years and lets the town think he's staff. Liam asked in March and again in July to take Mum out to the point on his boat; I said no both times. Ruby has been on nights since August and won't say why. **And the one kind thing:** Brad paid me back the van money in October, all of it, out of the blue, and I put it here because it is the least odd thing that happened this year and I wanted one nice thing on the list. His one addition: not the police. I've nothing they'd act on and I won't have them in your lives over a shelf. You four can do what they won't. Her close, kept: read this together, be careful, write legibly.

What he cut: the tin and the panel. What he kept that he could have cut: the lock, the pot and the four, because it is true and it closes the room on itself. What he added: the ban, three true things that lean, and one lie that only one living person can know is a lie, about him, and kind.

4. Brad before the night, on the night, and the fourteen days

Why he cannot walk. His exit is not a departure. It is a death. The deckhand's papers are for a man presumed drowned, because a living Brad Collins with a cash debt to a woman who forgets nobody is a man who is looked for, into a cash economy Margo audits, with a panel question still live in the trade; a dead one is grieved and forgotten. A death needs a grief the town will believe. Hers is that grief. And the month's end is her date, not his: on the first she has Margo write the loan up and starts asking where the van money went, which is the one conversation his exit cannot survive.

Day –19. He watches her lock his panel into her store and drive off with the keys. **Day –9.** With the new spare from the second pot, while she is at the slip, he reads her book of everything: the lock, the pot, the store, the keys cut and lodged and the packet's two in the harbour, the four envelopes, the tin, the shelf, the calling-

in and the date. He takes a sheet of her layout paper and her pen from the workshop. The plan is made in knowledge. **Day 0, the last Monday before the month's end.** He comes about the money; she pours two glasses; she goes up for the book to show him the figure; the landing. In the twenty minutes he waits he takes the book. He rinses his glass and puts it on the rack; hers stays on the side. Out by the back door at 22:30, lifted and pulled so it catches; the neighbour at N^o14 sees a man's back, a coat, hands empty; the book is under the coat. He is never in her house again.

Day 1 (canon). Liam lets himself in with the spare from the second pot at two, finds her, rings. Uniform, then Del: unwitnessed, head injury, foot of the stairs, front locked, back latched, no disturbance, one glass on the side; coroner's officer informed; door-knock: N^o14 saw her Monday morning and a man's back in the lane about half ten, a coat, nothing in his hands; noted, unidentified male, nothing to identify him against. **Day 12 (canon).** Her solicitor, informed of the death, posts the four envelopes as instructed; he does not know their contents; he will confirm the lodging to anyone entitled to ask and volunteers nothing to the other side's solicitor beyond what the administration requires.

The fourteen days. He does not go near the store, and it is the least-cost choice: nobody else can open it before the keys arrive (no fifth key; the packet's keys in the harbour; the keys never in her house; the store in no record the sister receives; a brick bay with no partition, roof or hinge to go through), and a cut or picked lock is the one event that makes the police look. The sheds are worked from first light; his own locker in the same corridor is a reason to be there at seven; his box gives him seven. From Day -9 he drafts at his own bench. On Day 14 at 07:20 he opens her store, reads her true letter, takes it and the panel to his own locker, and drives home. By ten the draft is conformed; by two the forgery and her mother are in her store; that evening the drafts, the true letter and the book go into his own grate. The boat owner saw a signwriter at her store door at twenty past seven, carrying a board between two doors, and thought her pupil was collecting her kit.

5. The room, week by week (replaces spine rows 14 to 60 in substance)

Day 14, 21:00. Torches, the padlock, a letter in her hand and her mother beside it. Margo: she's brought her mum. Brad hands Ruby the letter and lets Liam be the one who reaches. Liam carries the tube to Ruby's car. Read that night at Ruby's table. The first response is relief, and then the shame of relief, and then the lock. She changed her lock in October and told us four, and it happened again after. Nobody says the arithmetic aloud that night. Liam explains March and July the moment they are read. Ruby explains the nights. Ruby reads the kind line aloud and the room is glad of it. Ruby names the one line that did not sound like Vi: the police one; Liam answers it, because he knows why (Vi and the police, the night her mother died); Ruby lets it go, and it is the thing she will tell Ally she should never have let go. The slips: four addressees, Brad's the box that is on his van; nobody thinks about it. They decide, four of them, that Violet's sister hears nothing until they know what they are looking at. Weekly meetings agreed. The tube on Ruby's sideboard, label to the wall.

Day 15. The outward look, done in one evening, and the arithmetic said aloud. Liam: front locked, back latched, the spare in the second pot where she told us, one glass. Number 14 told him at the funeral what she told the police: a man's back in the lane at half past ten, going out the back. The back door, which Liam rehung in spring on the same visit as the window catch, does not catch unless you lift it as you pull; the four have cursed it every Tuesday since; whoever left knew, or found out in ten seconds; a narrowing thing, not a closing one. The closing thing is hers: she changed her lock in October, told us four the new place and nobody else, and it happened again after. Nobody else in her life: no cleaner, no lodger, no tradesman, a smart meter, a sister four years away. They look outward, and there is nobody there, and that is the worst thing that could

have happened to them. Nobody asks at the sheds, because nobody suspects the letter; the store is where Violet put things.

Meeting 1 (Day 19). The lists begin, about the people around each of them, as she asked, and there is nobody around any of them. Liam confirms the third of the yard. Nobody lists money: the one money fact in the room is on Vi's own list and it is a kindness. Where were we on the Monday night: Ruby on shift; Margo at home, alone; Liam alone at the yard; Brad at home, on foot, alone. Nobody has an alibi and the quiet man has the least. Ruby says the line the room needs, and nobody answers it: she thought she'd know, and she's dead.

Meeting 2 (Day 26). Everything odd about Violet. The shelf. The lock, and why she did not say why. Who had been in the back bedroom this year. Liam, honestly: once, the window catch and the door, spring. Margo underlines Spring.

Meeting 3 (Day 33). March and July, again, beside the catch, the pot and the back door. Brad: that's Liam, he'd have thought that. Ruby: Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her. Nobody looks at the sideboard. The room hears an ordinary explanation given quickly as one given before; it hears a kindness about her mother as an interest in the back bedroom.

Meetings 4 and 5 (Days 40, 47). The lists worked against each other; Ruby drives; Brad defends Liam each time and loses. By Day 47 it has landed on Liam without one line of the letter having said it.

Days 8, 45 to 53. Margo (structural change this round). She was never the estate's accountant. On Day 8 she handed the sister Violet's business books and told her the private loan book was not among them (shrug). Around Day 45 the sister's accountant rings about that book, and Margo tells him everything she knows about the money, privately, to the one professional entitled to ask: the private loan book existed and is missing; the van loan to Brad was on no paper, against her advice; Violet told her in late summer she meant to call it in for the hearing; she has no record of any repayment. She never mentions a letter. The accountant writes to Brad. Brad answers what he must, because the four have read his forgery: repaid in full, October, cash. Around Day 50 the accountant rings Margo back: Mr Collins says repaid in full; any record at all? Her book would have it, and it is gone. **That is the arrival:** Brad's own sentence coming back to her through a professional, beside the missing record. The estate can do nothing with an unpapered cash loan the debtor says is settled, and closes. What Margo now holds is not the money, which she has said in full to the estate; it is what the money means: the letter's one kindness and Brad's answer to the estate are the same sentence, and the only reason they would be is that they have the same author. That is an accusation of murder on a reading, and it is the one thing she cannot say. **Day 54, meeting 6:** she stops arguing with Brad and stops looking at the other two. Ruby asks. "I've said what I think." Ruby lets it go, the second thing she lets go. Brad is the only person alive who knows there is a lie in that letter and who can catch it (Violet told him on Day -110 that her accountant had told her to get paper), and he has just been asked by the estate on her account. He reads her silence; nobody else at the table can. **Day 60:** Kestrel Head, as ruled.

Day 82. After the room breaks, Ruby decides the sister should have her mother back, tells her Violet had locked her in her store at the sheds, and hands her the tube. The sister has the empty store's padlock cut. Nothing else is there. From there as ruled: Day 77 Tessa's screenshot; the withdrawals; Day 214; the review; the Gazette; Ally, who hears about the ashes from the sister, bitterly, in chapter 3.

6. Chapter 7: a suspect turn, honestly

By chapter 4 Ally holds, from the boat owner via the Tip Line and unaired, that "the young one" was at Violet's store at twenty past seven on the Monday morning, carrying a board between two doors. By chapter 6 she

holds the panel from the two signwriters and, from the café, that Violet was calling in money that autumn. In chapter 7 Ruby gives her the envelope: the solicitor's slip listing four addressees, one a box number, and the Saturday postmark. A box is cleared first thing; home delivery came after work. One of the four held his key by seven, and the boat owner saw him use it at twenty past. The letter the four read together at nine that night had been in his hands since morning. Chapter 7 claims no more than that: the man who defended Liam every week deserves the investigation nobody gave him. Why the listener believes it: the panel the town saw her carry and the letter never mentions; the one line that did not sound like Vi; and the letter's one kindness, that he paid her back unasked, in the autumn the café says she was calling it in. Not proof, and Ally says so. Proof arrives where the spine has it: the arrest on Day 333, the panel on his wall, the deckhand's papers.

7. What changes, what does not

Changes this round. The lock changed on Day -37 with one new spare, told; the trap as her engine and the room's pool-closer; the back door as a narrowing fact, rehung in spring, corroborated by the Day 1 record; Margo competent with the estate and never naming a letter, the accountant's second call as her arrival, her lock as silence about meaning; why Brad cannot walk, and what the first of the month costs him; the instruction with her reason (who has been near each of you); the kind line without the tell; the box for leaf and post; Day 1, Day 12 and the sheds written in.

Changes carried from earlier rounds. The premise device; the cold open's middle (section 13); chapters 1, 2 and 7 as listed before; the ashes for the board; intestacy; the sister with her own people; the loan open and the calling-in private; one glass; the store off the books and Day 82 via Ruby; the panel shown at the store door; keys cut, used and lodged in one morning; Brad reads the book on Day -9; Brad never in her house after Day 0; the box number; the bare key note; terminology per v1.8.

Does not change. The motive. The panel and the dosed tin. Brad's PO box, dawn read and same-day swap. His nine hundred days, the deckhand's papers, the vanish, the arrest under the deckhand's name on Day 333. Margo's six-week silence as the load-bearing lock, and her death. The survivors' fear of each other, the police look (row 25, R27), the Gazette, Ally's ten weeks. All four decisions. The notch.

8. The vo.3 round (ten findings; answers in force)

Brad and the padlock; chapter 7 not an inference; the machinery's scale; Margo (reworked since); the key question and Liam's line; the sister and the ashes; bare fact in the salt; Ruby to Del on Day 15; no date for the shelf; the first minute.

9. The vo.4 round (nine findings; answers in force)

Margo never engaged; the pool (now the lock change); the fourteen days; the fall made a killing (now the lane, the door and the lock); chapter 7 a suspect turn; Violet shows Brad; the sister told on Day 82; the letter dated; the panel in his locker.

10. The vo.5 round (nine findings; answers in force)

The loan open; one glass; the store off the books; the showing at the store door; his own bench and grate; packet keys off the slip; the solicitor's papers; the room never asks the sheds; Liam and the van money.

11. The vo.6 round (ten findings; answers in force)

The kind line for the candour; the asymmetry; keys in one morning; the back door (now narrowing only); Brad reads the book; Ruby's doubt answered; the spare moved (now the lock changed); no rucksack; the market manager; the slip.

12. The vo.7 round: ten findings and their answers (attack these)

#	Finding (Fable / GPT)	Answer built into vo.8
1	The Day 45 call cites the letter; Margo must correct the estate (both drivers)	Section 5: records only, all of them, never a letter; the accountant's second call is the arrival; her lock is silence about meaning.
2	Violet would change the lock (GPT)	Section 2: Day -37, one new spare, told; the trap; the pool-closer.
3	Liam sole source for the latch; the trick discoverable (both)	Section 5, Day 15: Day 1 record corroborates; rehung in spring; narrowing, not closing.
4	Brad would leave on Day -9 (GPT); the date (Fable)	Section 4: his exit is a death and needs a grief; the first of the month.
5	"About each other" beside "it isn't any of you" (GPT)	Section 3: the instruction with her reason: who has been near each of you.
6	The kind line's tell; chapter 7's café plank (Fable)	Section 3: "out of the blue"; section 6: the café disagrees with the letter.
7	The consequence on Day -110 (Fable)	Section 2 and 4.
8	The box and the flat (Fable)	Section 2: leaf and post to the box on the van.
9	Records not in the document (Fable)	Section 4: Day 1, Day 12; section 5: the sheds.
10	Margo's meeting-six sentence (Fable)	Section 5: "I've said what I think."

13. The first minute: the test

Two versions of the open's middle go to the three blind readers with the ruled vo.4 open as control. Version A as sketched; Version B brings "only two of them are still alive" and the tin's image inside the first sixty seconds. One question at the minute mark, unprompted: what are you afraid of right now. Nothing is ruled until the readers answer.

14. The new and changed facts, swept

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
The lock changed, one spare, told to four	Violet; the four; Brad	Suspect the four (Violet); use the spare (Brad)	She would rather be imagining it and writes it down for after; he uses it	Yes
The shelf after the lock	The four, Day 15	Close the pool	They do, on her own fact	Yes
Margo tells the estate everything about the money	Estate's accountant	Write to Brad; ask for records	Brad says repaid; no record; an unpapered cash loan; closes	Yes
The accountant's second call	Margo	Report the inconsistency	She has: no record, deceased meant to call it in, debtor says paid; the estate holds it and can do nothing; the inference is hers alone	Yes, and it costs her

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
Brad asked by the estate	Brad	Watch Margo	He does	Yes
Brad with nine days	Brad	Walk	His exit needs her death; the first of the month	Yes
The instruction's reason	The four	Look at the people around them	Nobody there; the lists turn inward on the salt	Yes
The kind line, unasked	The four	Believe it	They do; only Margo knows Vi was asking	Yes
Day 1, Day 12, the sheds	Police; solicitor; the room	As canon	Nothing	Yes

PROMPT FOR CHATGPT (paste everything below this line)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. This premise change has been attacked five times and reworked five times on the findings; sections 8 to 12 list those findings and the answers now built in. Your job is to break the sixth cut, not to improve it. Read the delta above in full. Attack on six fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. A finding from a previous round re-raised without engaging its answer does not count; if you think an answer fails, say exactly where it fails. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

1. **The lock.** Violet changes her lock on Day -37, tells only the four where the new spare lives, and the shelf turns again after. Find what a competent Violet does on the morning she finds her mother facing the door the second time, and say whether it ends the episode.
2. **Margo and the estate.** She tells the estate's accountant everything she knows about the money and nothing about a letter; the accountant asks Brad; Brad says repaid; the accountant rings her back. Find the next thing the accountant, the sister or the sister's solicitor does, and say what happens.
3. **Brad's death.** His exit is a faked death that needs a grief the town will believe. Find the cheaper grief, or the reason a competent man does not simply fake his death without hers.
4. **The instruction.** "Who has been near each of you." Find what the four's lists actually contain on Day 19 under that instruction, and whether Brad's three salted items survive being read beside them.
5. **Night one, again.** Find the line in the forged letter as now written that a competent person at the table catches on night one, and say what follows.
6. **The whole.** Take the device as it now stands and find the earliest competent action by any person in the story, on any fact, that ends the episode before its time. If there is none, say so.

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.